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Window to the Stars

by Burt Burlington

Warm underneath my covers, I was frozen in position, powerless against the nearing slim spine-chilling silhouette growing ever closer. Amy in the corner, barking, in total fear like me. The creature's dark slender hand covering my face. Darkness.

My eyes shot open; my vision still needed to sharpen. When they did, everything still felt as if they were spinning like rolling tennis balls. Holding my head between my hands while looking up, I felt my long nails pressed against my temple. I saw the tester hanging above me on the foot posts. *What a gorgeous bed I woke up in today.* This quenched the feelings of my night terrors and nauseous a bit.

Then, the hairs on my arms stood up, and adrenaline replaced the sleepiness in my blood. *Whose bed is this?* I threw the blankets up and crawled back, revealing my blue lingerie, my back pressed against the bed headboard. My eyes flew across the room. The floorboards were dark, with mahogany and oak planks laid in an intricate pattern. *This is not my house.* As confused and frightened as I was to wake up in a stranger's bed, I have to confess the it made me feel eerily at home. Classical Victorian-designed wallpaper –muted colors with fleur-de-lys– tastefully hung on the wall in harmony with the wooden furnishings,

both stemming from the same era—a dark vanity table on my right and a master bathroom to my left. A dark wooden door, closed shut, right in front of me. The entire décor reminded me of my grandma's house; similar, but unfamiliar.

I do miss my Mima. Waking up in a bed other than my own in a Victorian-era home, reminded me of the nights I would sleep over at Mima's when I was a child. I loved being away from my brothers, who would tease me and thought I was stupid just for being a girl, and by that, also "being gross." But I was Mima's favorite. We would spend entire weekends together. We did groceries together and went to bingo sessions, where all her friends thought I was the cutest thing and would give me candy. She taught me to knit, make apple pies, and we would joke about how stupid boys were, especially my brothers. I miss my Mima, Mima's always was my favorite place as a child.

While thinking of Mima, I thought of my other significant other, Amy. How scared she would be without me. *Did I fill her bowl the night before? Or closed the gate?*

While worrying about her, my eyes drifted on my left to a window. It was night, yet the stars outside were blinding and prettier than I had ever seen, and it seemed the streetlights were on because yellow light spilled into the room. The house is *probably facing the street*, I thought, *maybe I can recognize something*. Stepping out of bed I noticed I was wearing a light blue nightgown. *I have never ever owned a blue nightgown? Not to my knowledge*. I swallowed deeply, imagining the worst-case scenario. *Did a creep dress me in my sleep? And who was this creep, a 50-year-old man?* I wanted to get out of here. Fast.

Sitting on the bed, I carefully dropped my feet onto the floorboards; not wanting to alarm the creep downstairs by creaking on the old floors. The floors didn't make a sound, not a squeak nor squeal. It felt as if I stepped on marble museum floors. Carefully, still, I slid my way to the window, hoping I will discover where I am. The light from the streetlights poured into the bedroom.

My heart sank.

The light didn't come from the streetlights, it came from the stars themselves, from above, but also below!

Through the single-paned glass window, I could see millions of stars, the arms of galaxies, and pillars of stardust, possibly ranging lightyears. Never ever have I ever been so moved yet so terrified at beauty. Stars were sliding across the "night sky" as if it was nothing. A long belt of grey rocks, all in unique shapes, spanned across the bedroom window. Purple clouds, white stars, blue comets, yellow galaxies... While looking through them, I felt dizzy, and my chest felt strange. *I haven't breathed yet.*

Taking a deep breath, it turned to multiple. Rapid, short breaths. Hyperventilating. Panicking. I looked around. I tried looking at the house through the window. A wooden Victorian-era house. Floating through space. There was no ground. No grass, no street, no yard, and no sky. It felt as if spikes grew on the inside of my skull, piercing my brain.

What is happening?! I screamed in my tortured head.

I looked back and quickly walked to the vanity table. I looked at myself in the mirror. *I still looked like Rose, Me.* My make-up was fully done. I was beautiful, as beautiful as a 30-year-old woman can be. My red hair contrasted perfectly with my light blue lingerie, with the eyeliner, blush, and concealer done to a tee. Not even I could make myself look so stunning. However, on my neck I noticed three light blue symbols on top of each other. One was three vertical stripes with a circle around them, a circle with a dot in the middle, and lastly an abstract one I could only come close to describing by saying it looked like the Milky Way galaxy. Like tattoos, the light blue symbols were stuck to my skin. The characters were unknown to me.

Jealous of the beauty skills and terrified, I pinched my cheek, desperately hoping I would wake up. Nothing. Tears stung in my eyes, not from the pinch but from my soul and

body's sheer terror. *Where am I?! Who did this to me?!* I turned around and ran to the bathroom.

The bathroom had an old-fashioned clawfoot tub and a toilet that you had to flush with a string pull mechanic. The entire bathroom was colored sickly green and brown, though it was all squeaky clean. It reminded me of the time I scraped my knee on the long driveway at Mima's, and she took me into the bathroom to clean the wound. I looked at myself in the mirror, wishing I had simply scraped my knee. I turned the tap on, and miraculously, water came out. *This has to be a dream. How can water come out if we aren't on Earth?* I didn't think twice about it and started splashing water on my face, drinking while rubbing my face and neck.

I scrubbed my face so hard, as if washing dirt from the carpet. A neatly placed towel lay on the side of the counter, reminding me of a classy hotel room. I rubbed my face with the white towel, not caring if I would ruin it with my make-up. Pulling the towel from my face, I looked at myself, but I was not alone. A tall silhouette was hunched over and looking over my shoulder. SCREAMING, I looked back, just to see an innocent empty bathtub. The quick turn and the dizziness made me fall to the ground. Hitting my head on the ground.

I opened my eyes and looked at a vertical floor. I realized I had passed out. My face and naked legs against the cold tiles felt good, but they didn't cease my angst. I did not know what the figure was, all I knew was that I know I have seen it before.

Pulling myself up to the counter, I looked at myself in the mirror. I still was beautiful; my prettiness didn't seem to fade, not even a bruise from the fall. All my make-up was still exemplary, not faded in the slightest. *Surely, I must be dreaming?* I felt physically nauseous of perturbation. Whoever captured me, as afraid as I was of him, I needed to see him. I wanted at least the slightest reason to quench the revulsion I was feeling.

As reluctant as a woman can be, I slowly opened the wooden bed chamber door, trying not to make a sound. Pressing myself against the door to ensure complete control, I noticed the door didn't have that distinct smell. That distinct musty, 19th-century preparatory substances they used to coat wooden furnishings. It didn't smell like anything at all, and it felt more like cold metal than old wood. The door led to a dark hallway, kept warm by a red-carpet, with rich in patterns and colors. There were multiple doors on either side of the hallway, reaching all the way where the hallway turned right. This was the first time I noticed the height of the entire building. The ceilings were as high as French-Revolution-era palaces. I felt so tiny, walking through the doorway that was double my height. Tiptoeing my way to another tall door, the carpet crawled at the bottom of my naked feet. I tried opening the door. The door handle wouldn't move, not even an inch. The door stayed stationary, almost as if it was a wall. I tried the second of three doors. Again, nothing. I walked down to the end of the hallway and turned right—a staircase leading down on the other side. The stairs were decorated in the collective style the house was. *Maybe it leads to the foyer, the front door.* I took a step closer to the stairs. *Front door? I am floating through space!* Wishful thinking aside, I was desperate for answers, answers I was terrified to learn.

Looking down the hallway, around the corner, a tall skinny creature walked in. It had long legs, as tall as me, a slim torso with a forwardly bent chest, and a tall and skinny neck. I froze. The beast turned its neck to me, revealing its grey-white eyeless head, and seemingly no occiput.

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Branches ticking on the windows, the moonlight streaming in. I remember Amy grumbling at the end of my bed, laying between my feet.

“What is it girl?”

I saw Amy's silhouette sit up, most likely facing the door.

The grumbling became meaner, I was sure she has bared her teeth at this point.

She barked, even for a small dog like her, it was very loud. I sat up and looked at the door. Squinting, unable to see whatever she was barking at. I noticed she wasn't facing the door, but in the opposite corner of the room.

“Amy, you're scaring me.”

She answered with just another loud bark.

My vision cleared up when I looked at the corner of the room. And from out that dark corner, the same white slender creature revealed its petrifying head.

Amy jumped down to the ground, while I was frozen in fear.

The creature walked up to me, not caring for my small Amy. It spread its long fingers and reached for my face.

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The beast stepped towards me just like that faithful night. Yet this time, I didn't freeze. I turned around, and ran back from where I came. I ran back over the red-carpet as fast as my legs allowed me. I made my way back to the dead-end room, and crawled under my bed. While crawling, I looked down the hallway to see if the creature wouldn't see me. I pushed my body as deep under the bedframe as physics would let me. Looking down the hallway, holding my breath to mute the sound, I could see the menacing long limbs of the creature walk in. It stepped closer to the bedroom, but suddenly stopped. It tapped its praying mantis like arms, onto floorboards. Yet the floorboards did not sound hollow like wood, but like thick metal. It stepped closer again. I pushed myself further under the bed, but the wall behind me wouldn't let me. It tapped the floor again. It stood in the doorway of the bedroom. Motionless, it stood there, waiting for me to reveal myself. My heart stopped when a silver disc fell onto the ground in front of it. After that, the creature turned around, forgetting the

metal disc. Looking at it leave; I could see it hunched backbone, almost giving me scoliosis just by looking at it.

Finally having time to think, I asked myself: *What was that? Did I get drugged at a party? I never go out, so that is impossible, right?* Whatever it was, it was the reason why I was floating through space. I climbed from underneath the bed frame when I felt the coast was clear. Noiseless, with the help of the perfect carpenter's work, I made my way to the strange disc-shaped device. It was a silver plate, like a serving tray, but when I turned it around, it had a screen, like a computer tablet. The tablet was turned on, and a weird shape was projected on it. It looked like abstract brushstrokes that didn't form anything distinctly, like a Rorschach tests. Though, when looking at it, I could only see one thing, my dog Amy. Two small brush strokes completed her ears pointing up, while a stray droplet leaking down made her tongue. I wish I had her with me; I miss her so much. But I should be happy that she is not here with me...

Daydreaming about Amy's wet nose and the memories of where I would walk her through the park--she would get so messy--, I realized I was sitting on the floor of the hallway on the carpet, still with the tablet in my lap. I was so enamored by the device as if I could play around with it for hours on end.

But Amy was gone! Or at least, the stain that reminded me of Amy had changed into another non-concrete picture. This time it looked like a sort of rose. *Do those creatures want me to see this? What is the point? Do they want to communicate with me? What is the point of my dog and a rose? Are they saying my dog is dead? Please don't let that be!* I took a deep breath, trying to make sense of everything. *When did I get here?* I can't remember anything except for the figure in my room. My hunger for lost memories was bigger than my saturation of angst.

As I peeked around the corner from where I first saw that slender figure, I had my newfound screen of abstraction under my arm. Luckily, the slender thing was nowhere to be seen. Above the stairs, I was walking towards a two-story window with a perfectly aligned galaxy, purple and pink arms, and a yellow core behind it. A headache started to arise from trying to perceive the amount of stars, or dots, I was seeing. Taken aback by the view, I hardly realized I was standing at the top step. There was no sound from downstairs, and I figured this would be my best chance to make it down the stairs and not be seen.

The stairway brought me into the foyer. The foyer had beautiful wall decorations with an elk theme, on the walls, on the stair rail, above the doors, and on the floorboards. Then, a feeling of nostalgia crashed into me like a wave onto the side of a cliff. I saw a bordeaux greatcoat with a matching cloche hat and a white rose. *That's Mima's*. It felt like I was sleeping over at Mima's as a child again. I would walk down the stairs at 8 o'clock while Mima was already making breakfast. With the high ceiling and doors, it felt like I was the size of my 8-year-old-self again. *This gave me a feeling of comfort, the first time I felt it since I woke up in this wretched house floating through space*. Setting foot on the ground floor, or whatever you can call the ground floor if you are floating through space, I looked around for different clues. The front door was two times the size of me and was exactly the same as Mima used to have. Dark green, polished wood, golden knocker. Strangely, the outer facing side of the door faces inside the house. *Do I dare?*

I stepped closer to the nostalgic door. *Can I just leave?* I tried peeking through the opaque windows of hammered glass in the door, but I wasn't tall enough. *Do I want to?* I laid my hand on the doorknob, which was as big as my head and a foot above it. *Do I want to run the risk of suffocating in outer space to escape?* Yes. With all my strength, I tried turning the doorknob, but just like everything in this 19th century Victorian Era--yet remarkable condition--house, it wouldn't budge.

I didn't want my back turned for too long, as the front door was perfectly aligned with a long hallway, and I didn't know what could be hiding there. Exiting the foyer and entering the long hallway, I saw picture frames on the walls. Some were colored, some black and white, and some brown and white. But all pictures were missing the people's faces. None of the parents, children, not even dogs, posing in them, "looking" at the camera, had eyes to see, or a mouth to smile. A girl with pigtails sitting on a white chair, most likely taken in the 1920s. Or a picture of the man in uniform, most likely looking solemnly, but no way to know for sure. These pictures felt familiar, but I knew I had never ever seen images so disturbing. But then I saw a picture I knew all too well. It was a picture of Mima in her distinct red greatcoat and cloche hat in a round frame, yet her face was missing. Looking closer, her face was gone. I blinked, and suddenly, Mima's face was there. Smiling down to the camera as if her face was never an expressionless void. My breathing was starting to get heavy, and the world around me felt as if it was turning.

Swallowing the terror away, I noticed one of the doorframes not being barricaded by an immovable door. As I shuffled closer, I noticed the sound of cutting. As if rubber is being cleanly sliced in two. My curiosity got the best of me, and I peeked around the corner.

A slender alien was hanging off the ceiling with its appendages fastened and stuck to the roof and the floor, facing toward the doorway. It was yellow, instead of white, with green stripes and dots running down its appendages. Green tubes seemed to be suction cupped to the creature's head, back, and stomach. A white skeletal alien of the same race was slicing into the yellow one's chest as if operating on him. The white one cut through the chest skin and cleanly went through it. Purple organs, as dry as grapes, were underneath the yellowish skin. The hairs on my arms and back said enough. I jumped past the doorframe leading deeper into the hallway.

The hallway descended deeper, and the walls had become round like a submarine. Yet the same interior design remained. I had never ever seen this classic design be used in tubular shape. Wall decorations, carpet, and doorframes all were warped, as if the hallway just got rolled-up like a newspaper. My brain hurt just by looking at it. I used my hands and the strange tablet as a blinder to minimize the nausea. But when holding the tablet near my face, I saw that the pictures had changed again. This time, the stain looked like a person, screaming into my face. *What are they trying to tell me? Are they warning to not venture deeper?* Whatever they are trying to convey to me, should they be the ones I listen to?

The round-shaped hallway led to a large room. In front of me was a giant bay window with millions of stars, stunning stardust pillars, and asteroids flying behind it. Between me and the window was another slender creature with its back turned to me. It was seemingly steering a ship. Handling a steering wheel that reminded me of the hot hatchback I got when I turned sixteen. The plastic steering wheel, missing all the bells and whistles of modern cars, was attached to something that looked like a classic oven I used to make cupcakes in. My feet were nailed to the iron-cold wooden floor, and I stood there in utter confusion. The alien creature, casually turning the wheel similar to my Nissan Sunny GT, seemed to have noticed me. It slowly turned around, and the eyeless creature stared at me; I could feel it sensing me. It made a noise, a kind of roar, a noise I can't repeat in text or sound. Nor do I know how it made those sounds because it had no mouth. *This is the end.* I whispered in my own head. The creature faced its head to me but didn't move a muscle. It turned back and continued steering the house through the asteroid field. I was confused, not knowing if it truly saw me or didn't care. It felt as if the creature didn't mind my presence or that I had escaped my room. My feet started to move closer to the bay window, driven by the alluring beauty of the stars and interstellar bodies that took the stage before me and the eyeless being.

I walked up to the window, staring out into the beauty no living human being on Earth has ever seen. Stars and galaxies with color combinations I have never dreamed of or ever seen on the big screen in the cinemas back home. As lonely and frightened as I was, these feelings faded, and replaced by sheer awe. The sheer size of the never-ending space felt comforting because nothing mattered, and terrifying at the same time. But those feelings disappeared like the sun behind the Earth's horizon, when I realized that I didn't have anybody to share this view with. Not my parents, girlfriends, Mima, or Amy. Before I knew it, I felt a tear fall off my cheek and onto my light blue nightgown. I stood there, missing, longing, infatuated, and petrified. Until I heard that same unexplainable, untranslatable, un-understandable growl again.

I turned around, tears still in my eyes. Eight feet behind me stood the white and the yellow creature. *How could the yellow one be standing here, surely it was dead? I saw it being flayed.* Their lanky bodies and their heads towering over me, just observing me. The "undead" yellow and green striped being stepped closer to me, stretching out its arms. I stepped back, but the windshield blocked my way. The yellow creature stopped in its track. Observed me for a second. It stretched its thin hands out, with its palm facing up. Its fingers curled up and down in itself, as if gesturing I should hand it something. *But I didn't have anything, just the tablet.*

Then continued on, nearing me with its scary grasping appendages. I reached out the tablet to the beast. The beast was reaching for it, but I pushed myself off the window, shooting towards the daunting creature. Jumped through its legs. The beast was too slow. Running for the tubular hallway, the two creatures started chasing me.

I knew I couldn't outrun them for long; I was lucky to have a head start. Reaching the top of the circular hallway, I saw that the doorframe where I first saw the flayed being, was still open. I could hear the creatures clawing their way up to me, and I decided to hide there.

Stepping inside the room before the beings could see me, I tried getting as deep into the room as I could without making a sound. I snuggled in one of the corners and looked back at the open doorframe. My little corner was as black as the darkness of space outside the house. Past the doorway ran the white alien, now on four legs instead of two. It made that distinct yet inaudible grunt. Praying that the yellow one would pass me as well, I noticed that the space around me started to alight blue. Like God was about to appear out of nowhere. The light came from nowhere, it seemed, until I looked down and saw my nightgown had started illuminating. I tried hiding the light with my hands and feet, but I simply couldn't hide the light. While doing so, I noticed that the light also came from directly under my chin. I held my hand on my neck, and the light source from my neck disappeared. *The tattoo, it glows up.* I heard the steps from the hallway. The alien scream became louder and louder, like a chainsaw cutting through a glass.

I tried hiding behind a metal crate or whatever the thing was next to me. The creature stepped inside the room, not facing me. It looked to its left, and saw me. Terror shot through my veins. My heart pounding. It stepped into the room and walked straight for me. It stretched out its arms, ready to grab me. All I could do was scream.

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I sat in the bathtub, naked. I was sitting with my arms wrapped around my legs. Shaking. The pleasant warm water didn't take away my chills. Staring at the bubbles on the surface. Soap was running down my head from a sponge on top of my head. Handling the sponge, the lanky skeletal hands of the yellow creature stood beside the bath. Kneeling on the ground, it was stroking my back, caressing its hands across my wet arms, and running its thin fingers through my hair. The spidery appendages would only make me want to drown myself in the bath water. Washing me, it handed me the disk-shaped tablet. This time I could only see a scary monstrous head looking back at me with rows of teeth and evil eyes.

As I lay on my side in the bed in which I awoke in earlier today, I stared through the window. Stars fade, and galaxies drift by, knowing that the distance from between me and my loved ones would grow every second.